Aquifer Open Study Notes

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2 Kings

2 Kings 1:1

After Ahab died, the Moabites felt confident enough to declare independence from their Israelite rulers (see 2 Kings 3:4–5). This historical note foreshadows the problems Israel faced after Ahaziah's brief rule (see 1 Kings 22:51).

2 Kings 1:2

- An upper room or balcony with latticework was common. It allowed air to flow freely and offered some privacy, but lattice was easy to break.
- Baal-zebub (which means lord of flies) might be a mockery of a Canaanite god named Baal-zebul (which means Baal is prince). People later used this god's name for Satan (see study note on Matthew 10:25). Ahaziah worshiped Baal, like his father Ahab.

2 Kings 1:3–4

- The angel of the Lord in the book of Kings does not appear to be a christophany (a special appearance of Christ before his birth), unlike in other Old Testament texts such as Judges 6:11–18.
- Elijah, who had previously confronted Ahaziah's father, Ahab, delivered a two-part message to the king:
- he condemned the king for failing to recognize that the Lord, not Baal, is God (see 1 Kings 18:16–18), and
- he announced God's judgment of doom (see 1 Kings 21:17–24).

2 Kings 1:9–10

- The proud words of the army captain contradicted themselves. Elijah showed this: If Elijah was truly a man of God (a prophet of God), then his authority came from God. To ignore him was to invite danger (see Deuteronomy 18:15–19).
- Fire often represents God's presence in the Scriptures (see Exodus 3:1–6; 19:18; compare 1 Kings 18:38).
- Fifty soldiers was a typical group size (1 Kings 18:4); here it shows a division in Israel's military organization.

2 Kings 1:11–13

The king had apparently received a report about what happened to the previous group.

2 Kings 1:13–14

Unlike the first two officers, the third commander asked Elijah and God for mercy.

2 Kings 1:15

When the angel of the Lord (2 Kings 1:3) told Elijah what to do, he obeyed faithfully.

2 Kings 1:16

Is there really no God in Israel: God's message to Ahaziah stayed the same (see 2 Kings 1:3–4).

2 Kings 1:17

The second year of Jehoram's rule was 852 BC. During this time, he ruled alongside his father, Jehoshaphat, from 853 to 848 BC.

2 Kings 2:1–18

Elijah was taken up into heaven. At that moment, the role of prophet passed to Elisha, shown by the transfer of Elijah's mantle (cloak).

2 Kings 2:2–6

stay here: Elijah asked Elisha three times to stay behind while he traveled. Each time, Elisha refused and promised to stay with his master until the end.

2 Kings 2:8

Elijah folded his cloak and hit the water with it. These symbolic actions showed God's power (see Exodus 14:16, 21, 26–27; 17:8–13; 1 Kings 11:30–31; Ezekiel 4; 5:1–4).

2 Kings 2:9–10

The firstborn son was the main heir. So, he received twice as much of his father's estate (Deuteronomy 21:17). Elisha asked for Elijah's spiritual gifts and privileges from God to continue through him.

2 Kings 2:11

- chariot of fire ... horses of fire ... whirlwind: These symbolize God's powerful presence (see Isaiah 66:15).
- Elijah was taken into heaven, like Enoch (Genesis 5:24), without dying. Some believe Enoch and Elijah will return at the end times (see study note on Revelation 11:1–13).

2 Kings 2:12

Elijah was Elisha's spiritual father and personal mentor. Compare the tribute given to him at his death in 2 Kings 13:14.

2 Kings 2:13–15

Elisha took Elijah's cloak and parted the Jordan River. The other prophets saw that Elisha was truly Elijah's successor.

2 Kings 2:16–18

The prophets looked through the wilderness to make sure Elijah had not just vanished for a while (see 1 Kings 18:12). Elisha already knew the search was useless.

2 Kings 2:20–22

Elisha used a new bowl (Deuteronomy 21:3) filled with salt (Leviticus 2:13; Ezekiel 43:24) to ask God to purify the people and the environment. Elisha emphasized that the Lord, not he or the salt, purified the water.

2 Kings 2:23

- The group of boys might have been young adults. The Hebrew word used here can mean a young adult who is still learning a job. For example, Solomon asked God for wisdom because he was young and inexperienced (1 Kings 3:7). Joshua's spies in Jericho were also called by this term (Joshua 6:22–23).
- Calling someone baldhead was disrespectful. The young men told Elisha to go away (literally go up), mocking his role as Elijah's successor, given by God.

2 Kings 3:2

Ahab likely set up the sacred pillar (or stela) of Baal when he started Baal worship (see 1 Kings 16:32–33). People also erected similar stones for pagan gods in Judah (1 Kings 14:23). Jehu (2 Kings 10:26–27) and Josiah (23:13–15) later removed these pillars.

2 Kings 3:4–5

The Moabite rebellion (see 2 Kings 1:1) started when they stopped paying their yearly tribute. The Moabite Stone (Mesha Stela) describes how Israel controlled northern Moab during the time of Omri and Ahab. This control continued under the rule of Ahaziah and Joram.

2 Kings 3:4–27

One of Elisha's miracles took place during the war between Israel, Judah, and Moab.

2 Kings 3:6–7

Jehoshaphat quickly agreed to Joram's request, which was common for him when dealing with the northern kings (1 Kings 22:4; 2 Chronicles 20:35–37). Jehoshaphat's son, Jehoram, married Ahab's daughter, Athaliah (2 Chronicles 18:1; 21:6), which deepened Jehoshaphat's involvement with Israel.

2 Kings 3:8–9

the king of Edom set out: At this time, Edom was likely under Judah's control. Later, during Jehoshaphat's son Jehoram's reign, Edom rebelled and gained independence from Judah (2 Kings 8:20–22). The southern route through Edom bypassed strong Moabite defenses, but it was risky due to limited water.

2 Kings 3:11–12

Is there no prophet of the LORD here?: Diviners or prophets often traveled with armies to understand the divine will. Jehoshaphat wanted to hear from a true prophet to know the Lord's plans for the battle (see 1 Kings 22:7). However, this time he waited until the campaign had started before asking the Lord.

2 Kings 3:13–14

Elisha joined because Jehoshaphat was there, even though he was involved with the pagan Joram.

2 Kings 3:15

But now, bring me a harpist: Music inspired the prophetic spirit (see Psalm 49:4).

2 Kings 3:18–20

The supply of water was easy for the Lord. It signaled that God would help the allies defeat Moab's army.

2 Kings 3:24–25

The army of Israel destroyed the towns. Elisha's prophecy came true, but Kir-hareseth was not completely destroyed.

2 Kings 3:26

The Moabite king might have tried to break through enemy lines to get revenge on the Edomite king or to escape through a weak spot in the allied lines.

2 Kings 3:27

there was great fury against the Israelites: The Hebrew phrase translated as intense anger is also used to describe the Lord's fury against Israel for breaking their covenant (Jeremiah 21:5; 32:37; Zechariah 7:12).

2 Kings 4:1

- The widow's husband was part of the prophets who worked with Elisha (2 Kings 2:3–18).
- take my two children as his slaves: The law of Moses let a creditor make a debtor and their children work as slaves to pay off a debt (Exodus 21:2–4; Leviticus 25:10).

2 Kings 4:4

- shut the door: Elisha was meeting a private need. The miracle was not meant for public display.
- Olive oil was a basic part of daily life. It also had commercial value for trade (see 1 Kings 5:11; 2 Chronicles 11:11; Hosea 12:1).

2 Kings 4:5–6

Elisha was not present during the miracle so the woman and her son would know that the Lord's power provided it.

2 Kings 4:8–37

Elisha's interactions with the woman from Shunem are shown in two similar parts (2 Kings 4:8–20, 21–37). Shunem was a border town in the land given to the tribe of Issachar (Joshua 19:18).

2 Kings 4:9–10

- The Shunemite woman knew Elisha was a true prophet, a holy man of God. She wanted to offer him hospitality during his travels (see Isaiah 58:7; Hebrews 13:2; 3 John 1:5).
- She provided a small room on the roof, accessible by an outside stairway, ensuring privacy for both Elisha and his hosts.

2 Kings 4:11–14

- Elisha wanted to repay his host's kindness.
- Gehazi his servant: Gehazi was Elisha's apprentice, just as Elisha had been with Elijah (1 Kings 19:21). It was common for a prophet to seek advice from his assistant.

2 Kings 4:15–16

Compare similar promises and responses in Genesis 18:9–15 and Luke 1:6–20.

2 Kings 4:18–20

My head! My head!: The boy may have suffered a sudden brain illness, such as an aneurysm. His mother's faith and character were tested when he died suddenly while sitting on her lap.

2 Kings 4:21

laid him on the bed of the man of God: By doing this, the woman kept her son's death a secret and showed her belief in Elisha's power to perform a miracle.

2 Kings 4:24–26

- Mount Carmel was about twenty miles northwest of Shunem. The long trip and the woman's hurry made Elisha suspect something bad had happened to the child.
- Everything is all right: The woman ignored Gehazi's questions. She was determined to speak only with Elisha.

2 Kings 4:27

she clung to his feet: This showed deep respect and a plea for help. The woman shared her feelings with Elisha (see Matthew 28:9; Luke 8:41, 47; 17:16; Revelation 1:17).

2 Kings 4:28

Losing her son took away all the joy she had felt when he was born. It felt like a cruel trick.

2 Kings 4:29

- Elisha told Gehazi not to talk to anyone on the way, showing how serious and urgent the mission was. Jesus gave similar instructions when he sent out the seventy-two disciples (Luke 10:4).
- Placing Elisha's staff on the child's face showed the prophet's intention to connect with the boy and call upon God's power.

2 Kings 4:31

but there was no sound or response: Elisha's staff had no magical power; only God creates life (Acts 17:25–28).

2 Kings 4:33

closed the door: Elisha did what he had told the widow to do earlier (2 Kings 4:4). If God performed the miracle, it would not be for everyone to see. Only the mother knew about the boy's death, and only she needed to know about Elisha's prayers to God for the boy's life.

2 Kings 4:34–35

lay on the boy: His actions and faith in the Lord were like Elijah's (1 Kings 17:17–24).

2 Kings 4:36–37

Once more, Gehazi called the woman (2 Kings 4:12, 15), and she fell at Elisha's feet (2 Kings 4:27), this time filled with gratitude instead of sorrow.

2 Kings 4:38

Similar to Bethel (2 Kings 2:3) and Jericho (2 Kings 2:5, 15), Gilgal was a hub for a group of prophets (2 Kings 2:1). Elisha led these groups and sat at the head of the table during meals.

2 Kings 4:39–41

The men quickly realized the young man's wild gourds were poisonous. They didn't want to be poisoned or waste the stew during a famine, so they asked Elisha for help. The flour symbolized God's miraculous provision of food.

2 Kings 4:42–44

- barley bread from the first ripe grain: This offering was like the first crops usually given to God (Leviticus 23:20) and to the priests (Deuteronomy 18:4–5) as their share. During the famine, Elisha shared the offering with everyone.
- Elisha fed a hundred people with a sack of fresh grain and twenty loaves of barley bread, which foreshadowed the miraculous acts Jesus did (Matthew 14:15–21; 15:32–38). Nothing is impossible for God (Matthew 19:26; Luke 1:37; 18:27).

2 Kings 5:1

- The king of Aram was likely Ben-hadad II who ruled from 860 to 843 BC.
- the LORD had given victory to Aram: The Lord rules over all nations (Psalms 47:8; 99:1–2; Romans 13:1).
- a leper: Naaman's ability to be part of society and Gehazi's later social freedom (2 Kings 8:4–5) suggest the issue was not Hansen's disease but another serious skin condition (see Leviticus 13:10–11, 45–46).

2 Kings 5:2–3

During Joram's rule, tensions between Israel and the Arameans caused Aramean raiders to attack the northern kingdom (see 2 Kings 6:8, 24).

2 Kings 5:5–6

The expensive gifts and royal letter highlighted Naaman's wealth, his importance to the Aramean king, and Elisha's reputation. Unlike Ahaziah, who sent messengers straight to the temple of Baal-zebub in Philistia (2 Kings 1:2), the Aramean king used diplomacy by sending Naaman to King Joram first.

2 Kings 5:7

tore his clothes: Tearing one's clothes was often a sign of strong emotion. For example:

- Agitation (2 Kings 11:4)
- Grief (Genesis 37:34; 2 Samuel 13:31)
- Sorrow (2 Kings 6:30; Job 1:20; 2:12)

Due to ongoing distrust and hostility between the Arameans and Israelites, Joram thought the Aramean king wanted to start a fight, as had happened during his father Ahab's time (1 Kings 20:1–12).

2 Kings 5:8

Elisha did not respect King Joram (2 Kings 3:14), but he sent the message to show the Lord's power.

2 Kings 5:9–12

Instead of welcoming Naaman, who came to pay for his healing, Elisha left him at the door and sent a messenger to speak with him. Naaman expected special treatment because of his status and felt let down by Elisha's refusal to meet him and by the instructions to wash seven times in the Jordan River. He thought the Jordan was inferior to the rivers of Aram. Washing in the Jordan would visibly show that only Yahweh, the God of Israel, could heal Naaman.

2 Kings 5:13–14

Naaman put aside his pride. He followed the instructions from the man of God and felt God's healing power. Following God's guidance leads to blessings and purity (Psalm 119:9–11).

2 Kings 5:15–16

- No God ... except in Israel: Naaman's physical healing led to his spiritual conversion. Like the Samaritan leper healed by Jesus, Naaman returned to thank his healer (Luke 17:15–16).
- Naaman offered a gift out of gratitude, but Elisha refused. God's grace and blessings cannot be bought with money, gifts, or favors (Isaiah 55:1–5; Romans 2:4; 1 Corinthians 2:12; Ephesians 4:8).

2 Kings 5:17

soil: In ancient Near Eastern customs, people linked a nation's god with its land. Naaman thought he needed Israelite soil to build an altar and worship Israel's God correctly.

2 Kings 5:18

The name Rimmon appears in Tabrimmon (1 Kings 15:18), the father of Ben-hadad I. In Aramean, the god's

name is actually Ramman (meaning the thunderer), a storm god mentioned in Assyrian writings. The spelling Rimmon (meaning pomegranate) might be a pun to mock the god.

2 Kings 5:22–23

Naaman believed Gehazi's made-up story and was glad to reward Elisha.

2 Kings 5:24

the hill: The Hebrew word means hill or high point in a city. People often built citadels in these locations (2 Chronicles 27:3).

2 Kings 5:25–27

Gehazi could not hide his actions from Elisha. Gehazi's lies and abuse of his position led to Elisha's disapproval and losing his role as Elisha's servant. It also resulted in Gehazi getting Naaman's leprosy, showing that Gehazi had spiritually switched places with Naaman.

2 Kings 6:1–2

a log ... a place to live: The forest areas of the Jordan Valley near Jericho and Gilgal offered various types of wood for building (see 2 Kings 2:1, 4).

2 Kings 6:5

The Hebrew text shows that the ax head was made of iron, which was valuable when few iron tools existed. Since it was borrowed, losing it was even more distressing.

2 Kings 6:8–10

Elisha knew the Aramean king's attack plans, so he could warn Joram of danger. Healing Naaman (2 Kings 5:1–19) seemed to improve relations between Elisha and Joram (see 3:13–14).

2 Kings 6:11–14

- When the king of Aram found out that Elisha could warn the king of Israel ahead of time, he ordered his men to capture the prophet.
- Dothan was about ten miles north of Samaria. Archaeologists have confirmed the city existed during this time.

2 Kings 6:15

We do not know the name of Elisha's worried servant. He likely replaced Gehazi (2 Kings 5:27).

2 Kings 6:16–17

Elisha prayed to the Lord to help the young man see the angels protecting the city. Angels play a role in world events (Psalm 34:7; Daniel 10:20–11:1; Hebrews 1:7).

2 Kings 6:21

My father: Elisha used this respectful term when talking to Elijah (2 Kings 2:12), just as Naaman's servant did with his master (2 Kings 5:13).

2 Kings 6:23

great feast: The Israelites treated the Arameans kindly, so the Arameans stopped raiding Israel. However, this peace was only temporary.

2 Kings 6:24–25

The famine was so severe that people ate and sold normally forbidden foods at high prices. For example, donkey meat was forbidden in the laws about unclean foods (Leviticus 11:1–7). Dove's dung might have been a type of wild vegetable, but during sieges, people sometimes ate dung (Isaiah 36:12). The dove's dung might also have been used as fuel.

2 Kings 6:26–29

Cannibalism (the act of eating human flesh) in extreme times was part of God's warning of judgment for unfaithfulness and disobedience (Deuteronomy 28:53, 57). It also happened during the siege that led to Jerusalem's fall (Lamentations 4:9–10).

2 Kings 6:30

- When Joram heard about cannibalism in the city, he tore his clothes in despair.
- He wore burlap under his robe against his skin as a sign of mourning.

2 Kings 6:31

the head of Elisha ... on his shoulders: Decapitating enemies was common (2 Kings 10:6–8; 1 Samuel 17:51; 31:9; 2 Samuel 4:7–8, 12; 20:22; Matthew 14:11) in the ancient Near East. Joram thought the problem arose because Elisha had spared Ben-hadad's troops earlier (2 Kings 6:22–23). Ben-hadad had also been pursuing Elisha (2 Kings 6:13), putting the entire city at risk.

2 Kings 6:32

Elisha knew Joram was sending someone to kill him, and the king was close behind.

2 Kings 6:33

- the king said: This might mean the messenger was delivering the king's exact words.
- Since the siege's suffering seemed to come from the Lord, Joram thought praying for rescue was pointless.

2 Kings 7:1

- This is what the Lord says: Even though Joram was negative and unfriendly, Elisha shared a hopeful message. Tomorrow, everything would change, and good products would be available again.
- Twelve quarts will cost only one piece of silver, compared to the prices in 2 Kings 6:25.

2 Kings 7:2

Joram's officer did not believe, so he missed out on God's blessings.

2 Kings 7:3

These four men were outcasts due to their illness and stayed outside the city gates (Leviticus 13:45–46; see Luke 17:11–13).

2 Kings 7:5–7

The Hittites lived just north of Aram and often fought with the Arameans.

2 Kings 7:8–9

The men decided to share their good luck with the people in Samaria.

2 Kings 7:10–12

Joram thought the Arameans might have set a trap to ambush the Israelites. Joshua used a similar tactic to capture the city of Ai (Joshua 8:3–23).

2 Kings 7:13–17

The abandoned items showed how quickly the Arameans fled, and the Israelites took goods from their camp. As Elisha predicted, food was now plentiful. Joram's skeptical officer was knocked down and trampled to death.

2 Kings 7:18–20

Repeating Elisha's earlier talk with Joram's officer highlights how the prophecy came true exactly as predicted.

2 Kings 8:3

appeal for her house and her land: Her property might have been held in trust or taken away.

2 Kings 8:4–5

Gehazi used to be Elisha's servant. He had risen in status to serve the king. Even though Joram often opposed Elisha, he seemed curious about the amazing things Elisha had accomplished.

2 Kings 8:6

Restore all: The woman not only got her land back, but Joram also ensured she received all the income from crops sold during her absence. Joram, who sometimes showed less noble traits (2 Kings 3:13–14; 6:31–33), demonstrated higher ethical standards than his father Ahab did with Naboth's vineyard (1 Kings 21:1–16).

2 Kings 8:7

Elisha's ability to visit Damascus showed the high respect Israel's enemies had for him. This visit completed the task first assigned to Elijah (1 Kings 19:15).

2 Kings 8:8

Will I recover? See 2 Kings 1:2.

2 Kings 8:9

forty camel loads of every good thing: While gifts were common when consulting a prophet (see 1 Samuel 9:6–8), Ben-hadad's gifts were extravagant. This showed his wealth and respect for Elisha.

2 Kings 8:10

Elisha told Hazael to inform the king that he would recover because his illness was not deadly. However, Elisha knew Ben-hadad would die.

2 Kings 8:11

Elisha began to cry because he saw the terrible acts Hazael would do to God's people when he became king (2 Kings 8:28; 9:14–15; 10:32–33; 12:17–18; 13:3, 22).

2 Kings 8:13

a mere dog: In the ancient Near East, people viewed dogs as scavengers and held them in low regard. King Shalmaneser III of Assyria noted in his records, "Hazael, son of a nobody, seized the throne."

2 Kings 8:15

Hazael reigned in his place: Although he delivered Elisha's message to Ben-hadad, the next day he sped

up Elisha's prophecy by killing the king and taking the throne. Hazael might have wrongly thought the prophecy gave him a divine right.

2 Kings 8:16

Jehoram ruled Judah with his father, Jehoshaphat, for five years. He became king on his own in the fifth year of Joram's reign in 848 BC.

2 Kings 8:17

Jehoram ruled from 853 to 841 BC. He shared the throne with his father, Jehoshaphat, for five of those years.

2 Kings 8:18

did evil in the sight of the LORD: He married Ahab's daughter, Athaliah, and followed the kings of Israel by worshiping idols. Some believe Psalm 45 was written for Jehoram and Athaliah's marriage, which united the royal families of Judah and Israel (see Psalm 45:12; Athaliah was Jezebel's daughter, the princess of Tyre).

Although the marriage temporarily united the kingdoms, it led to terrible spiritual consequences. Influenced by Athaliah, Jehoram introduced false worship practices (2 Chronicles 21:11), including Baal worship (2 Kings 11:17–18).

2 Kings 8:19

- Even though Jehoram was wicked, God did not destroy Judah. He honored his promise to David (2 Samuel 7:11–16).
- The Lord promised to keep David's descendants on Judah's throne as a symbol of God's grace (1 Kings 11:36). God's promises to David are ultimately fulfilled in Jesus (Ezekiel 34:23–31), who is the light of the world (John 4:1–5).

2 Kings 8:22

- Libnah was a town in southwestern Judah, near the Philistine border. During Jehoram's rule, the Philistines and Arabians attacked Jerusalem. They killed all of Jehoram's sons except Ahaziah (2 Chronicl,es 21:16–17).

2 Kings 8:24

Jehoram died from a painful stomach disease and was not buried in the royal tombs (2 Chronicles 21:18–20).

2 Kings 8:25

the twelfth year of the reign of Joram: Ahaziah became king of Judah in 841 BC. This year was crucial in ancient Near Eastern history. By the end of the year, both Joram and Ahaziah were dead. Hazael became the confirmed king of Damascus, and Shalmaneser III of Assyria controlled the region.

2 Kings 8:28–29

- Once again, a king of Judah joined an Israelite king to fight the Arameans at Ramoth-gilead (see 1 Kings 22:1–40).
- Jezreel acted as a second capital for Israel during Ahab's rule (1 Kings 21:1); he went there after seeing Elijah's challenge with the prophets of Baal on Mount Carmel (1 Kings 18:46).

2 Kings 9:1–3

Jehu received a prophetic endorsement to become king, but this did not mean approval of all his actions. However, he did have a divine command to punish the house of Ahab for their wickedness and idolatry (2 Kings 9:8–10).

2 Kings 9:1–37

The writer summarizes Jehu's takeover, which started Israel's fourth dynasty, in four steps:

1. Elisha sent a prophet to the army camp at Ramoth-gilead to anoint Jehu as Israel's next king (2 Kings 9:1–10).
2. Jehu's soldiers learned about the prophet's visit and declared Jehu king (2 Kings 9:11–15).
3. Both Joram and King Ahaziah of Judah were killed (2 Kings 9:16–29).
4. Jezebel was killed (2 Kings 9:30–37).

2 Kings 9:2

This Jehoshaphat is different from the earlier king of Judah, who was Asa's son.

2 Kings 9:4–10

The young prophet explained to Jehu how to carry out God's judgment against Ahab's family (see 1 Kings 21:20–24).

2 Kings 9:11

madman: God's faithful servants are sometimes mocked or rejected as insane ("mad") or foolish by others (see Jeremiah 29:26; Hosea 9:7).

2 Kings 9:13

The bare steps of the house acted like a throne, and the soldiers' cloaks served as a carpet. Spreading garments this way showed respect (see Matthew 21:8).

2 Kings 9:14–15

conspired: Jezreel, where Joram was healing from his injuries, was about forty-five miles away. Jehu needed to act quickly and secretly for his coup.

2 Kings 9:16

While Jehu was being honored by his men as their king, Joram and Ahaziah were still in Jezreel (2 Kings 8:28–29; 9:14–15).

2 Kings 9:21

the property of Naboth the Jezreelite: Ahab took this property from Naboth, and it became the site where Ahab's family line ended, fulfilling Elijah's prophecy (1 Kings 21:19–24).

2 Kings 9:22–24

The accusations against Joram were similar to those against his father, Ahab, and his mother, Jezebel (1 Kings 16:30–33; 21:25–26).

2 Kings 9:27–28

- The road to Beth-haggan went south along the eastern edge of the Jezreel Valley, passing Ibleam and continuing to Samaria.
- Megiddo ... he died there: King Ahaziah fled to Samaria, where he was captured and taken to Jehu (2 Chronicles 22:8–9). Chronicles and Kings together suggest that although Ahaziah was wounded at Gur, he managed to reach Samaria. Later, Jehu's men caught him and brought him to Jehu, where he was executed.
- The writer of Chronicles links Ahaziah's capture with Jehu's killing of Ahab's descendants and some of Ahaziah's relatives (see 2 Kings 10:1–17), suggesting Ahaziah evaded capture for a while. This account is very brief, mentioning Ahaziah's death and burial before describing later events.

2 Kings 9:30

The narrator goes back to the events at Jezreel. Jezebel, knowing Jehu was coming and she would soon die, dressed up and stayed proud until the end.

2 Kings 9:31

Jezebel accused Jehu of being like Zimri, possibly to remind him that Zimri's quest for power was brief (1 Kings 16:15–19).

2 Kings 9:32–33

- Jehu showed his violent nature by trampling Jezebel's body under his horses' hooves.
- The Hebrew word translated eunuchs can mean emasculated males, but it can also mean important officials.

2 Kings 9:34

Jehu entered the palace to eat, silently declaring he had taken the throne.

2 Kings 9:34–37

The scene showing Jezebel's end fulfilled Elijah's prophecy against Ahab's family (1 Kings 21:21–24; 22:34–38).

2 Kings 10:1

Ahab's sons (this term can also mean grandsons) might have been with Joram in Jezreel while he healed from his wounds (2 Kings 8:29). However, they fled to Samaria to escape Jehu's purge.

2 Kings 10:1–27

The writer highlights two key events during the time Jehu was king:

- Jehu killed everyone who might claim Joram's throne (2 Kings 10:1–17), and
- Jehu executed the priests of Baal (2 Kings 10:18–27).

2 Kings 10:2–5

Jehu's message about the city's military strength to protect Ahab's remaining family was actually a war declaration. The leaders of Samaria understood this. Jehu led Israel's main army and had already shown his power and ruthlessness at Jezreel. The leaders were so scared that they agreed to follow all of Jehu's orders.

2 Kings 10:6–7

In the ancient Near East, people often beheaded their enemies (2 Kings 6:31–32; 1 Samuel 17:46, 51; see also Matthew 14:11).

2 Kings 10:9–10

But who killed all these?: Jehu said that the Lord wanted these events to happen, as communicated through Elijah (1 Kings 19:16–17; 21:21224).

2 Kings 10:11

Jehu killed all of Ahab's remaining relatives and associates, leaving no survivors. He went beyond his divine

mission, seeking power for himself. The Lord, through the prophet Hosea, condemned his actions (Hosea 1:4).

2 Kings 10:12–14

- We do not know the exact location of Beth-eked, but it was near Jenin.
- Ahaziah's relatives responded to Jehu, which led to their downfall. Jehu thought their connection to Ahaziah, and indirectly to Ahab's family through his daughter Athaliah, might give them a claim to Israel's throne. In this second series of executions, Jehu once more went beyond his orders to end Ahab's dynasty.

2 Kings 10:15

Jeremiah describes Jehonadab as the leader of desert nomads who protested against society's corrupt religion (Jeremiah 35). Recab was a Kenite (1 Chronicles 2:55). While most nomadic Kenites lived in southern Judah, some were in Galilee (Judges 4:17; 5:24). Their opposition to the royal family's unfaithfulness may have led them to support Jehu as a savior and reformer.

2 Kings 10:18–19

Jehu tricked the people by promising to support and increase the worship of Baal.

2 Kings 10:18–27

By killing the priests of Baal, Jehu tried to remove the worship connected with Ahab's family. He also wanted to end the people's loyalty and attachment to the former royal family.

2 Kings 10:25–26

inner room of the temple ... the sacred pillar: Canaanite temples had a recessed area in the wall for a sacred stone image. The temple of Baal in Samaria had a sacred altar to Baal and an Asherah pole, which Jehu's men destroyed. Later, Josiah's purge of Baal worship in Judah involved burning and demolishing the Asherah pole in the temple in Jerusalem (2 Kings 23:6).

2 Kings 10:27

Converting the destroyed temple of Baal into a public toilet (latrine) made it unclean and unsuitable for future religious ceremonies.

2 Kings 10:28–29

Even though Jehu ended Baal worship in Israel, he continued the worship of gold calves at Bethel and Dan. This practice was started by Jeroboam I. It remained part of the state religion (1 Kings 12:28–30). Eventually, it contributed to the fall of the northern kingdom (2 Kings 17:21–23).

2 Kings 10:30

God kept his promise of a royal family for four generations. Jehu's descendants, Jehoahaz, Jehoash, Jeroboam II, and Zechariah, ruled as kings of Israel.

2 Kings 10:31–33

- Because Jehu was unfaithful, the Lord started reducing Israel's territory. This was one of the curses for breaking the covenant (Deuteronomy 28:25).
- The Aramean king Hazael moved south, taking over areas east of the Jordan River, north of Moab's border. The Arameans kept pressuring Israel during Jehu's rule and into his son Jehoahaz's reign (2 Kings 12:17–18; 13:3).

2 Kings 11:1–16

Athaliah, the mother of King Ahaziah of Judah, was the daughter of Ahab and Jezebel and the wife of King Jehoram of Judah (2 Kings 8:18, 26). As queen mother, she had significant influence, but she used it for evil (2 Kings 8:18, 27; 2 Chronicles 22:3–4). Her plans included destroying the rest of the royal family (see 2 Chronicles 22:10).

While Ahab's family in Samaria was completely destroyed, Athaliah took control in Judah through a massacre similar to Jehu's slaughter of her family in Samaria.

2 Kings 11:2

- Jehosheba was likely born to Jehoram by a wife other than Athaliah, making her Ahaziah's half-sister (see Josephus, Antiquities 9.7.1).
- The infant Joash was born to Zibiah of Beersheba (2 Chronicles 24:1), possibly a lesser-known wife of Ahaziah. This might have allowed the baby's birth to go unnoticed by Athaliah.

2 Kings 11:3

If discovered, Jehosheba could have been executed for hiding Joash for six years. Athaliah ruled the land from 841 to 835 BC.

2 Kings 11:4

- Jehoiada the priest knew his plan could be seen as treason (2 Kings 11:14). He also did not fully trust the men he wanted to join him. Before he revealed the existence of Joash, the rightful heir to Judah's

throne, he required them to swear an oath of loyalty. These men went to the towns of Judah and brought the Levites and family leaders to the temple in Jerusalem, where they made a covenant with Joash (2 Chronicles 23:3).
- The Carite mercenaries came from the Aegean region. They served as the king's bodyguards (2 Samuel 20:23).

2 Kings 11:5–8

Jehoiada organized the royal guard into specific groups. Some protected the young king. Others took positions at the palace, the Sur Gate (also called the Foundation Gate, 2 Chronicles 23:5), and behind the palace guard. Additional guards stood watch at the Lord's temple. Every effort was made to secure the king and the anointing site.

2 Kings 11:11–12

With all the palace guards in place and their weapons ready, Jehoiada brought out Joash before the people and crowned him king. He also gave him a copy of God's laws. The king was to receive a copy of the law, make his own copy, and "read from it all the days of his life" (Deuteronomy 17:18–19). Jehoiada's actions strongly contrast with Athaliah's pagan rule.

2 Kings 11:13–14

- The pillar might be one of the two that Solomon placed at the temple entrance (1 Kings 7:15–22; 2 Chronicles 23:13). Or the Hebrew word could mean a raised platform built for the occasion so that everyone could see the new king.
- Athaliah cried out "Treason!" But this was ironic, since she herself had murdered to make herself queen (2 Kings 11:1).

2 Kings 11:16

Athaliah died at the gate where horses enter the palace, similar to her mother Jezebel, who died under Jehu's horses (2 Kings 9:33).

2 Kings 11:17

Renewing the covenant was crucial after years under pagan rule. The law required covenant faithfulness and regular renewal (Deuteronomy 31:9–13), and Israel followed this at key moments in its history (see 2 Kings 23:1–3; Joshua 24).

2 Kings 11:18

- The temple of Baal might be the one found in Ramat Rahel, about three miles south of Jerusalem. Just as Jehu ended Baal worship in the northern kingdom (2 Kings 10:18–27), the people of Judah destroyed this pagan temple and executed its priest.
- Jehoiada placed guards at the temple to prevent attacks from Athaliah's followers and her false religion.

2 Kings 11:19–20

The city was calm, showing that the kingdom respects God and his laws (Isaiah 35:10; 65:18–24; Jeremiah 33:6–16).

2 Kings 11:21–12.21

The record of Joash's reign follows a typical format:

1. It describes when he became king (2 Kings 11:21–12:3)
2. It tells about his royal activities (2 Kings 12:4–18)
3. It gives the closing notice of his reign (2 Kings 12:19–21).

The main focus is Joash's efforts to repair the temple of the Lord (2 Kings 12:4–16). Later, when the army of Aram [the Arameans] invaded, Joash took treasures from the temple and gave them away to protect his city (2 Kings 12:17–18).

2 Kings 12:1

Joash was king from 835 to 796 BC.

2 Kings 12:2–3

- Joash was grateful to Jehoiada, the priest who guided him. Joash stayed loyal to the Lord while Jehoiada lived. However, after Jehoiada died, ungodly leaders persuaded Joash to abandon the Lord and adopt Canaanite customs (see 2 Chronicles 24:17–22).
- Joash's failure to destroy the pagan shrines led to spiritual compromise. Allowing these shrines in Judah had previously angered God (1 Kings 14:23–26) and would do so again during Joash's time (2 Chronicles 24:23–24).

2 Kings 12:4–8

Joash ordered the collection of funds from the cities of Judah (2 Chronicles 24:5) for temple repairs. The money came from special Levitical taxes, a census tax (2 Chronicles 24:9), and voluntary donations. After some time, the priests still had not repaired the temple. So Joash took control of the project and assigned others to manage the repairs (see also study note on 2 Chronicles 24:4–8).

2 Kings 12:9–11

Joash's plan to collect and distribute money for temple repairs involved placing a large chest in an easy-to-reach spot for donations. When Joash told the people about the need for a tax and voluntary offerings to finish the repairs, they "rejoiced and brought their contributions, and they dropped them in the chest" (2 Chronicles 24:9–10). Once they had enough funds, the money was given to the construction supervisors, and the temple repair and restoration began.

2 Kings 12:17

- Hazael was a constant enemy of God's people (2 Kings 8:28; 9:14–15; 10:32–33; 13:3). He killed the Aramean king Ben-hadad II and took the throne (2 Kings 8:15). Hazael likely attacked Israel and Judah after the Assyrian king Shamshi-adad V died in 811 BC and before Adad-nirari III, who ruled from 810 to 783 BC, began campaigns in 805 BC, capturing Damascus in 802 BC. Without Assyria's control, Hazael could attack southward.
- There is debate about whether Gath is the well-known Philistine city (1 Samuel 5:8; 6:17) or a Hebrew city also called Gittaim (2 Samuel 4:3; Nehemiah 11:33).

2 Kings 12:18

- consecrated items ... gold: Solomon and Asa had given these treasures to the temple earlier (1 Kings 7:51; 15:15).
- Hazael had started attacking Jerusalem, and Joash was injured in the battle (2 Chronicles 24:25). Paying tribute to Hazael might have stopped more damage to the city.

2 Kings 12:20

- Beth-millo: This area was on a ridge of the eastern hill of Jerusalem, called the City of David. Solomon built supporting terraces there (1 Kings 9:15).
- The road to Silla is not known from other sources.

2 Kings 12:20–21

The king was killed in 796 BC by some of his own officers. They acted in revenge for his murder of Zechariah, the son of Jehoiada (2 Chronicles 24:21–22, 25).

2 Kings 13:1–2

Jehoahaz ruled from 814 to 798 BC. He started ruling Israel when King Joash of Judah began repairing the Temple (2 Kings 12:6). Jehoahaz continued the state religion started by Jeroboam I (1 Kings 12:26–33), so his spiritual evaluation was negative.

2 Kings 13:3

- Hazael, who took the throne of Aram in Damascus by killing the previous king Ben-hadad II (2 Kings 8:15), kept oppressing the northern kingdom.
- Ben-hadad likely worked as a commander in Hazael's army until he became king in 802 BC after his father.

2 Kings 13:4–5

- Jehoahaz sought the favor of the LORD, and the LORD listened: Despite Jehoahaz's poor spiritual state, God kindly answered his prayer. The Lord kindly answers the sincere prayers of His people (see also 2 Kings 4:32–35; 6:17–20; 19:14–28; 20:2–6; 1 Kings 3:8–14; 13:4–6; 17:21–23; 18:36–39; Psalm 34:4–7; James 5:16).
- the LORD gave Israel a deliverer (compare Judges 3:9, 15): Scholars have suggested many possibilities for Israel's rescuer. The most likely is King Adad-nirari III of Assyria, whose westward campaigns led to the capture of Damascus in 802 BC.

2 Kings 13:6

- Even after God saved them, Israel kept sinning. This led to the fall of the northern kingdom (2 Kings 17:21–23; 1 Kings 14:15–16).
- This Asherah pole (a Canaanite fertility symbol set up by Ahab, 1 Kings 16:33) was apparently not destroyed during Jehu's removal of Baal worship (2 Kings 10:26–29).

2 Kings 13:7

Years of Aramean attacks weakened Israel's army. Only God could prevent Israel's destruction (2 Kings 13:4–5). In the end, only God can save humanity when it is helpless and lost (Psalm 35:10; Romans 5:6–8).

2 Kings 13:10–13

- The narrator unusually combines Jehoash's accession statement with the usual closing notice about his reign. This setup lets him highlight final details about Elisha (2 Kings 13:14–21) and Israel's ongoing issue with Aram (2 Kings 13:22–25) before returning to Jehoash's war with King Amaziah of Judah in 2 Kings 14:8–14.
- in the Book of the Chronicles of the Kings of Israel: See study note on 1 Kings 14:19–20.

2 Kings 13:14

- Jehoash cried over Elisha, showing he still had some spiritual awareness.
- the chariots and horsemen of Israel: Jehoash's tribute to Elisha echoes Elisha's words when Elijah left (2 Kings 2:12).

2 Kings 13:15–17

- Elisha put his hands on the king's hands: This gesture gave spiritual strength for the upcoming battle with the Arameans at Aphek.
- Aphek was east of the Sea of Galilee (1 Kings 20:26), so the eastern window faced the battle site.

2 Kings 13:18–19

Jehoash knew the arrows symbolized victory over Aram (2 Kings 13:17), but he did not act on it. By striking the ground only three times, he unknowingly limited his success against the Arameans. His son Jeroboam II achieved final victory later (2 Kings 14:25–28).

2 Kings 13:20–21

- Elisha's death offers a chance to share one last story about the prophet.
- The Moabite raiders seemed to plan their attacks on Israel during the early harvest, before the summer heat.
- The dead man came back to life when his body touched Elisha's bones, showing that Elisha's prophecy would come true. Weakened Israel (2 Kings 13:7) would recover and drive away the Aramean invaders (2 Kings 13:25; 14:25; compare Ezekiel 37:1–14).

2 Kings 13:23

Even though Israel often broke its promises, God stayed true to his covenant with Abraham (Genesis01 12:1–3; 13:15–17; 15:18–20; 17:6–8). By mentioning Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob, the writer highlights Israel's spiritual connection with the Lord and its right to the promised land (see Genesis 50:24; Exodus 3:6, 15–16; 6:3, 6–8; Deuteronomy 6:10; 9:5; 34:4).

2 Kings 13:24–25

- Ben-hadad, son of Hazael, became the king of Aram in Damascus in 802 BC. He ruled for 22 years over a weakening kingdom.
- Adad-nirari III of Assyria caused significant damage to the Arameans from 805 to 802 BC. This allowed King Jehoash of Israel to further weaken them. As the prophet Elisha predicted, Israel defeated Ben-hadad three times and regained its towns. Jehoash's limited success set the stage for Jeroboam II's major victories over the Arameans (2 Kings 14:25).

2 Kings 14:1–2

Amaziah ruled for twenty-nine years from 796 to 767 BC and shared power with his son Uzziah starting in 792 BC.

2 Kings 14:3–4

Although Amaziah's spiritual evaluation was acceptable, he did not fully commit to serving the Lord like his ancestor David (2 Chronicles 25:2). David remained the spiritual benchmark for judging the kings of Judah (2 Kings 16:2; 18:3; 1 Kings 15:5, 11). Judah struggled with the ongoing issue of tolerating long-standing pagan shrines (2 Kings 12:3; 1 Kings 14:23; 15:14; 22:43).

2 Kings 14:5–6

When Amaziah executed his father's killers, he obeyed the law that says parents and children should not be punished for each other's crimes (Deuteronomy 24:16; see also 2 Chronicles 25:4). He put the killers to death but did not kill their children.

2 Kings 14:7

- 10,000 Edomites: Amaziah's victory is briefly mentioned here but detailed in 2 Chronicles 25:5–15. God granted Amaziah this win but later reprimanded him. He was criticized for hiring Israelite soldiers and for bringing home and worshiping Edomite gods.
- The Valley of Salt is about three miles south of the Dead Sea.
- Sela is traditionally seen as a site among the rocks and cliffs near Petra in modern Jordan. Capturing this well-defended location showed that Amaziah's victory was given by God.

2 Kings 14:8

Amaziah challenged Israel's King Jehoash, possibly seeking revenge (see 2 Chronicles 25:13). Amaziah might have also grown too confident and proud after his recent win over Edom.

2 Kings 14:9–10

Jehoash responded with a parable (see Judges 9:7–15). Basically, Amaziah had as much chance of beating Israel in war as a small thistle demanding something from a strong cedar tree. Amaziah and Judah would be defeated as easily as a random step would crush the proud thistle.

2 Kings 14:11–12

Beth-shemesh, a fortress town fifteen miles west of Jerusalem, was a natural site for the battle between Israel and Judah. The city's history dates back to when Judah took control after the Danites moved north (Joshus 21:16; see also 1 Samuel 6:1–14; 2 Chronicles 28:18).

2 Kings 14:13–14

The complete destruction of Jerusalem's wall and the looting of the city show Jehoash's decisive victory. Taking treasures from the temple and palace and capturing hostages were common actions by victorious Assyrian kings. See also 2 Kings 12:17–18; 18:13–15; 24:13–14; 25:8–21; 1 Kings 14:25–26.

2 Kings 14:17–18

- Some believe Jehoash took Amaziah to Samaria, where he stayed captive until Jehoash died. After his release, Amaziah ruled with his son Uzziah for fifteen years.
- the Book of the Chronicles of the Kings of Judah: See study note on 1 Kings 14:29–31.

2 Kings 14:19–20

- Like his father Joash (2 Kings 12:20–21), Amaziah was killed by assassins. The writer of Chronicles says his lack of faith led to the plot against him (2 Chronicles 25:27).
- Lachish, southwest of Jerusalem, was where King Sennacherib of Assyria won a key battle during his invasion of Judah in 701 BC (2 Kings 18:14). Nebuchadnezzar II also captured it during his attack on Jerusalem in 588 BC (Jeremiah 34:7).

2 Kings 14:21

Uzziah's fifty-two-year reign ended in 740 BC. He started as co-ruler with his father at age sixteen in 792 BC. It seems Jehoash and Amaziah also made their sons co-rulers before going to war to ensure a smooth government transition.

2 Kings 14:22

Elath, built by Solomon (2 Chronicles 8:17) on the Gulf of Aqaba, served as a key trade gateway to the Red Sea.

2 Kings 14:23

In the fifteenth year of King Amaziah's rule in Judah, Jeroboam II began his independent reign in 782 BC. He ruled for forty-one years, including the time he ruled with his father from 793 to 782 BC.

2 Kings 14:24

Jeroboam II continued the false religion started by Jeroboam I (1 Kings 12:28–33) that eventually caused Israel's downfall (2 Kings 17:21–23; 1 Kings 14:16).

2 Kings 14:25

- At this time, Israel and Judah lived peacefully, allowing both kingdoms to thrive and regain nearly all the land Solomon once controlled (see 2 Chronicles 26:6–15).
- Lebo-hamath, mentioned in Egyptian and Assyrian records, was about forty-five miles north of Damascus in the Beqa' Valley. Jeroboam's conquests show the northern kingdom's military strength. Israel defeated the Arameans because Aram was weakened by Adad-nirari III of Assyria's earlier conquests.
- Jonah is the well-known prophet who predicted Nineveh's destruction but felt disappointed when God spared its repentant people (Jonah 3:3–4:3).

2 Kings 14:26–28

- He saved them by the hand of Jeroboam: God saw the people's helplessness and stayed true to the covenant with Israel's ancestors (2 Kings 13:23).
- the rest of the acts of Jeroboam: The narrator suggests Jeroboam's God-given power and wealth. The Samaria ostraca (inscribed pottery fragments) also shows that this was a time of prosperity. The prophecies of Hosea and Amos reveal that despite the wealth during Jeroboam's reign, the Israelites did not turn to the Lord.

2 Kings 15:1–3

- The name Uzziah means Yahweh is my strength.
- fifty-two years: Uzziah reigned from 792 to 740 BC. During this time, Assyria was weakening, and Israel and Judah had friendly relations. Uzziah's strong faith brought God's blessing, leading to Judah's greatest prosperity since Solomon's time (2 Chronicles 26:9–10).

2 Kings 15:4

Even though Uzziah had a positive spiritual evaluation, he still allowed worship at the pagan shrines (2 Kings 14:4).

2 Kings 15:5

Because Uzziah took over the duties meant for priests (2 Chronicles 26:16–21), the Lord punished him with leprosy. His son Jotham became co-ruler around 750 BC. Although Uzziah was isolated and could not perform public duties, he might have still held polit-

ical power. King Tiglath-pileser III of Assyria, who ruled from 744 to 727 BC, during his first western campaign from 744 to 743 BC, mentioned an opponent named Azariau, who many scholars believe was Uzziah.

2 Kings 15:8–12

Zechariah, the son of Jeroboam II, was not as skilled as his father. Zechariah continued the wrongdoings that the first Jeroboam had led Israel to commit. God had promised Jehu a royal line lasting four generations (2 Kings 10:30). Zechariah's six-month reign completed that promise.

2 Kings 15:13

Jabesh was a town east of the Jordan River in northern Gilead. It may have been the hometown of Shallum, whose reign was even shorter than Zechariah's. Shallum was killed in the same way he had killed Zechariah (2 Kings 15:10).

2 Kings 15:14

- Tirzah was the capital of the northern kingdom during Israel's first two royal families (1 Kings 14:17; 15:21, 33; 16:8).
- Menahem served as an army commander.

2 Kings 15:16

- In Tirzah, Menahem learned that Shallum had assassinated King Zechariah. Menahem gathered his troops and marched toward Samaria.
- ripped open all the pregnant women: This horrible wartime atrocity was also recorded in Assyrian and Babylonian texts. This act is also linked to King Hazael of Aram (2 Kings 8:12). See also Hosea 10:14; 13:16; Amos 1:13.

2 Kings 15:19–20

- Pul: This is another name for the Assyrian king Tiglath-pileser III (see 2 Kings 15:29; 16:6). The name Pul is taken from the Babylonian language. Tiglath-pileser III took the throne of Assyria in 744 BC and led effectively until he died in 727 BC.
- When Tiglath-pileser started the western campaign to reclaim land from Aram, Menahem paid him a large tribute of thirty-seven tons of silver to prevent him from invading Israel.
- Although Menahem's name means comfort, the unstable conditions in the northern kingdom offered little relief for God's people during his rule from 752 to 742 BC.

2 Kings 15:23–25

Menahem's son Pekahiah ruled for only two years before Pekah plotted to kill him. Pekahiah followed the sinful religious practices started by Jeroboam I (1 Kings 12:26–33). Pekah, an army commander, had likely been competing for the throne for a while.

2 Kings 15:27

fifty-second year of Azariah's reign: Pekah became king in the last year of Uzziah's rule, 740 BC. Due to the relationship between Tiglath-pileser and Menahem, Pekah limited his influence to Gilead while Menahem ruled from 752 to 742 BC. After Menahem died, Pekahiah appointed Pekah as an army commander. This role gave Pekah more support and allowed him to make himself king of Israel in 740 BC.

2 Kings 15:29–30

- During his second western campaign from 734 to 732 BC, Tiglath-pileser attacked Israel again. Pekah had joined forces with King Rezin of Aram in a poorly planned anti-Assyrian alliance (see Isaiah 9:1). As a result, Tiglath-pileser captured much of Israel's northern and eastern lands.
- Pekah's failed political strategies caused unrest in Israel, leading to his assassination by Hoshea. Hoshea likely acted to appease the Assyrian king and save the northern kingdom. In his records, Tiglath-pileser claimed he placed Hoshea on the throne and received a large tribute from him.
- The twentieth year of Jotham, starting from his co-regency with his father Uzziah in Judah, was 732 BC, the year he died.

2 Kings 15:32–33

In the second year of King Pekah's reign, Jotham began his first full year as an independent ruler. He had been co-ruler with his father for the previous ten years.

sixteen years: This period spans from when Jotham began co-ruling with his father Uzziah in 750 BC until his son Ahaz became the main ruler of Judah in 735 BC.

2 Kings 15:34–35

- Jotham did what pleased the Lord, but he let people continue worshiping at pagan shrines.
- rebuilt the Upper Gate of the house of the LORD: The prosperity from Uzziah's reign continued under Jotham. Jotham expanded Jerusalem's wall at the hill of Ophel and worked on many sites in Judea (2 Chronicles 27:3–4). He also defeated the rebellious Ammonites (2 Chronicles 27:5), whom Uzziah had previously subdued (2 Chronicles 26:8).

2 Kings 15:37

Rezin ... Pekah: See 2 Kings 16:5.

2 Kings 16:1–2

In 735 BC, during the seventeenth year of King Pekah's reign, Ahaz began to rule. He had been co-ruler for eleven years, but now he officially became king. This marked his transition from being under his father Jotham, who ruled from 743 to 735 BC, to ruling in his place from 735 to 732 BC. Ahaz likely had his official accession ceremony after his father's death in 732 BC. The author of Kings counts Ahaz's reign as lasting sixteen years, from 731 BC (the year after his father died) to 715 BC. See also study note on 2 Kings 17:1.

2 Kings 16:2–3

- David was Ahaz's ancestor. He is the benchmark for judging the spiritual character of Judah's kings (2 Kings 14:3; 1 Kings 15:3, 11).
- he walked in the ways of the kings of Israel: Ahaz was one of Judah's most wicked kings. He adopted Israel's false religion and the pagan practices of other nations, even sacrificing his own son in fire (see Jeremiah 19:5; 32:35). Levitical laws forbade such sacrifices as detestable to the Lord (Leviticus 18:10; 20:1–5), yet God's people continued the practice (Isaiah 30:33; Jeremiah 7:31) until Josiah's reforms (2 Kings 23:10).

2 Kings 16:5–6

Rezin ... Pekah: This alliance between the kings of Aram and Israel was made to resist Assyrian control under Tiglath-pileser III (2 Kings 15:29–30; Isaiah 9:1). They attacked Judah to force it into the alliance or to replace its king with someone they preferred (Isaiah 7:3–6). This led to captivity and many deaths in Judah (2 Chronicles 28:5–15). Isaiah notes that Rezin and Pekah wanted to put a new king on Judah's throne (Isaiah 7:3–6). Judah also faced attacks from the Edomites and Philistines (2 Chronicles 28:17–18). These events were seen as God's response to Ahaz's terrible spiritual practices, which caused great sin in Judah (2 Chronicles 28:5, 19).

2 Kings 16:6

The Berean Standard Bible uses Aram because that is the word found in the standard Hebrew text of the Old Testament (the Masoretic Text). Some other translations, like the New Living Translation, follow ancient versions such as the Greek Septuagint or the Latin Vulgate, which have Edom. Since Elath was located in the south near Edom, many scholars think Edom makes better sense in this passage. But the Berean Standard Bible stays close to the Hebrew wording, which says Aram.

2 Kings 16:7–9

Instead of trusting in God's help (Isaiah 7:7–16), Ahaz asked Tiglath-pileser III of Assyria to save him from his enemies. Tiglath-pileser succeeded, leading to Rezin's death, the capture of Damascus, and the deportation of its people in 732 BC. This also helped remove Pekah as king of Israel that same year (2 Kings 15:29–30). However, the rescue was costly; Ahaz paid a large tribute, and Assyria's involvement made Judah a vassal state (a state under the control of another).

2 Kings 16:9

The location of Kir is unknown; it was the original home of the Arameans (Amos 9:7).

2 Kings 16:10–11

Ahaz noticed the altar of the Arameans and had a copy made to imitate their religious practices.

2 Kings 16:12–13

The king started using the new altar by making traditional offerings on it (see Leviticus 1–3; Numbers 15:1–10; 28:9–15, 24, 31; 2 Kings 6:8–23; 7:11–20). Unfortunately, these offerings on a non-religious altar by a leader lacking spiritual integrity made a mockery of their true spiritual significance.

2 Kings 16:14

Solomon originally placed the bronze altar in front of the temple (see Exodus 40:6; 2 Chronicles 4:1; 7:7–10). At first, Ahaz positioned his new altar so worshipers would reach it before the bronze altar. Then Ahaz moved the bronze altar to the north side of the new altar, making the new altar the main place for sacrifices.

2 Kings 16:15–16

Ahaz ordered that the daily sacrifices (Numbers 28:1–8) and the king's and people's offerings be made on the new altar. He then limited the bronze altar to his own private use. The text says this was to seek guidance, likely meaning he intended to use it for pagan divination. This demand showed arrogant disrespect toward the Lord and his worship. Uriah the priest obeyed the king instead of resisting him (2 Kings 16:10–11, 16).

2 Kings 16:17–18

- The side panels and basins from the water carts and the Sea were made of bronze (see 1 Kings 7:25–40). Ahaz might have used them to pay tribute or for another project.
- on account: At the king of Assyria's request, Ahaz removed the canopy leading to the inner court and the king's private temple entrance. Judah lost much freedom because Ahaz trusted the Assyrian king's military help (2 Kings 16:7–8, 10).

2 Kings 16:19

the rest of the acts of Ahaz: Ahaz rejected the Lord by removing and destroying the temple's utensils (2 Chronicles 28:24). He closed the temple and stopped its services, promoting pagan practices instead (2 Chronicles 28:25; 29:7). Ahaz's complete change in Judah's worship was similar to Jeroboam I's actions (see 2 Kings 3:3; 13:2; 16:2–4; 17:21; 1 Kings 12:25–33; 16:26; 22:52).

2 Kings 17:1

- Hoshea began to rule over Israel in 732 BC.
- Hosea's reign is noted as starting in the twentieth year of Jotham (2 Kings 15:30) and during the twelfth year of King Ahaz's rule in Judah. Ahaz likely co-ruled with Jotham from around 743 BC, when he was twelve, but his official reign started in 731 BC (2 Kings 16:2). Therefore, the references to Ahaz's reign align.

2 Kings 17:1–23

The report of the northern kingdom's fall has two main parts:

1. Events during the reign of Israel's last king, Hoshea, including the capture of Samaria and the deportation of Israel's people (2 Kings 17:1–6);
2. The reasons for Israel's fall and Assyria's conquest:

- Israel's many sins (2 Kings 17:7–17) that led to God's judgment (2 Kings 17:18–20), and
- the major sin of Jeroboam I, who started Israel's widespread disobedience to God (2 Kings 17:21–23).

2 Kings 17:2

Hoshea did evil things, but not as much as those before him. The details are unclear.

2 Kings 17:3–4

- King Shalmaneser V took over from his father Tiglath-pileser III in 726 BC. Hoshea might have thought this change in leadership would let Israel break free from Assyrian control. However, by not paying the yearly tribute, he provoked Shalmaneser's retaliation.
- send envoys to King So of Egypt: Some scholars think the name So is short for Pharaoh Osorkon IV, who ruled from 730 to 715 BC. Others believe So refers to Pharaoh Piankhy, who ruled from 747 to 716 BC. They see the biblical name So as a Hebrew version of one of Piankhy's titles. Some suggest So is the city of Sais, the capital of Pharaoh Tefnakht, who ruled from 727 to 720 BC. Regardless of who this king was, it is clear Hoshea's hope for Egyptian support was a mistake.

2 Kings 17:5–6

- the king of Assyria: Historical records say Shalmaneser V of Assyria, the ruler from 726 to 722 BC, conquered Samaria, but Sargon II (who ruled Assyria from 721 to 705 BC) claimed he captured the city. Sargon might have been the commander when Samaria fell and then became king after Shalmaneser's death during the siege.
- invaded the whole land: The Assyrians would destroy the area around an enemy's main city before attacking it.
- The ninth year of King Hoshea's reign was 722 BC.
- carried away the Israelites: The Assyrians deported people to prevent future rebellions. Sargon also brought other people to Israel to create a mixed population (see 2 Kings 17:24–25).
- Halah was northeast of Nineveh in Assyria.
- The Habor River is a branch of the Euphrates River in northwestern Assyria.
- Gozan was on the Habor River northeast of Haran (see Genesis 12:4). Assyrian records from the area include names that are clearly Israelite, possibly showing the deportation of Samaria's people.

2 Kings 17:7

- sinned against the LORD ... who had brought them out of the land of Egypt: Their downfall came from repeatedly being unfaithful. Instead of staying loyal to their Redeemer, they worshiped other gods.
- Israel's rescue from Egypt is a common theme in the Old Testament. It appears in:
- the poetic writings (Exodus 15:1–18; Psalms 77:13–20; 105:26–45; 106:7–12; 114:1–8; Habakkuk 3:3–15),
- the prophets (Isaiah 63:11–14; Jeremiah 2:1–8; 32:21–23; Ezekiel 20:10–12; Micah 6:4), and
- the historical writings (Joshua 3:5; 4:14, 18–24; 1 Samuel 12:6).

2 Kings 17:8–13

Israel committed many sins, including pagan rituals and practices. Whether done openly or in secret, God knew about them all. Israel's kings often started these practices by building pagan shrines, sacred pillars, and Asherah poles. They copied pagan sacrifices and idol worship (2 Kings 10:29; 15:18, 28; 1 Kings 12:28–33; 15:34; 16:30–33).

People from all parts of Israelite society, both royalty and commoners, continued these sins. They ignored warnings from God's prophets, including Isaiah, Hosea, Amos, and Micah.

2 Kings 17:11

provoking the LORD to anger: When God is angry, he is not mean or bad-tempered. Instead, human wrongdoing angers him because people have turned against God and harmed each other. God deals with human wrongdoing through his justice (see also 2 Kings 13:3; 17:17–18; 21:6; 22:13, 17; 23:26–27; 24:20; Romans 3:23; 6:23; 14:10; 2 Corinthians 5:10; Colossians 3:6; 1 John 1:8–10).

2 Kings 17:14–15

Like their ancestors (Deuteronomy 10:16; 1 Samuel 12:6–9; Psalm 106:28), the Israelites continued to be unfaithful to the Lord (Isaiah 65:6–7; Amos 2:4; see Acts 7:51–53).

2 Kings 17:16–17

all the commandments of the LORD: The narrator lists specific examples of Israel's disobedience. These include:

- the two metal calves set up at Dan and Bethel (1 Kings 12:28–30),
- the Canaanite fertility symbol called an Asherah pole (2 Kings 13:6; 17:10; 1 Kings 14:23; 16:33; Micah 5:14),
- the ongoing worship of Baal (1 Kings 16:31–33; Hosea 2:13; 13:1), and
- the detestable Molech rituals (2 Kings 16:3; Psalm 106:37).

2 Kings 17:18–20

- The LORD was very angry: God's anger is a fair response to evil that requires justice.
- even Judah did not keep the commandments of the LORD: This hints at the future fall of the southern kingdom as well (2 Kings 25:1–21).

2 Kings 17:21–23

All of Israel's wrongdoings and disobedience were linked to the sins of Jeroboam I (1 Kings 12:26–33).

2 Kings 17:24

- The Assyrians exiled the Israelites to other regions they controlled (2 Kings 17:6) and sent different groups to settle in Israel. By mixing these diverse peoples, the Assyrians aimed to control the population better and shift their loyalties to Assyria.
- Samaria became the official name of this new Assyrian province.

2 Kings 17:24–41

The writer adds information about later events in Israel, like foreigners moving into the land and the mixed population's blended religious practices.

2 Kings 17:26–31

- The king of Assyria was Sargon II. He ruled from 721 to 705 BC.
- the God of the land ... has sent lions: People in the ancient Near East believed a land's peace and success were tied to its god and religious practices.
- One of the priests returned to Bethel, but his teachings on worshiping the Lord were likely influenced by Jeroboam I's religion and mixed with pagan practices.
- The foreigners also continued to worship their own gods. They added the worship of Israel's God to their own practices. Most of the false gods mentioned here are unknown. Jewish scribes may have changed their names.
- Nergal was the Mesopotamian god of the underworld. Nibhaz and Tartak were probably Elamite gods.

2 Kings 17:32–34

They worshiped the LORD, but they also served their own gods: The Hebrew faith, already mixed with Jeroboam I's religion, now included many foreign customs. Genuine worship of the Lord nearly vanished. Only a few faithful Israelites responded to Hezekiah's later invitation to come to Judah for the Passover celebration (2 Chronicles 30:10–19).

2 Kings 17:35–39

According to Israel's covenant with the Lord (Exodus 20:5; Deuteronomy 6:4–15), Israel was to worship only the Lord. Only God could truly save and protect them from all enemies.

2 Kings 17:40–41

worshiped the LORD but also served their idols: The Samaritan religion mixed the worship of Israel's God with other religions. This kind of mixture is called syncretism (an eclectic combination of religions). Because of this, Samaritans were later viewed with suspicion and treated with contempt (see Nehemiah 4:1–2; 10:28–31; John 4:7–9).

2 Kings 18:1–2

the third year of the reign of Hoshea ... over Israel: Hezekiah became co-ruler with his father, Ahaz. Hoshea started his reign in 732 BC, so Hezekiah began around 728 BC at age twelve. When Ahaz died in 715 BC, Hezekiah became the only ruler at age twenty-five. He then ruled for twenty-nine years from 715 to 686 BC.

2 Kings 18:1–12

The statement about Hezekiah becoming king (2 Kings 18:1–2) includes a detailed review of his spiritual dedication (2 Kings 18:3–7a). It is followed by information about the political situation during his reign (2 Kings 18:7b–12).

2 Kings 18:3–4

- Unlike Ahaz (2 Kings 16:2), Hezekiah was more like David. Hezekiah destroyed false worship objects, including pagan shrines, sacred pillars, and Asherah poles (see 2 Kings 16:3–10; 17:9–11, 19).
- The bronze serpent used by Moses (Numbers 21) had become an object of improper worship.

2 Kings 18:5–6

Hezekiah trusted in the LORD: He was the best among all the kings of Judah. Later, Josiah was unmatched in following the law of Moses (2 Kings 23:25). These two kings were examples of devotion during times of declining spirituality.

2 Kings 18:7–8

- Because Hezekiah was deeply committed to his faith, God blessed him, and he succeeded in all his endeavors. Hezekiah began a series of reforms, including:
- cleaning, repairing, and renovating the temple (2 Chronicles 29:3–36);
- celebrating the Passover (2 Chronicles 30); and
- restoring important worship practices in Judah (2 Chronicles 31:1–19).
- He rebelled against the king of Assyria: In the ancient Near East, rebellions and stopping tribute payments often happened when a new ruler took power. King Sennacherib of Assyria replaced Sargon II in 704 BC. Assyria's focus on issues in southern Mesopotamia at that time might have encouraged Hezekiah. Assyria responded by invading Judah in 701 BC (2 Kings 18:13–19:36).
- He also defeated the Philistines, who had been a threat during Ahaz's rule (2 Chronicles 28:18).

2 Kings 18:9–12

The narrator mentions Samaria's fall to show Assyria's dominance at the time. Samaria fell because Hoshea turned away from God. This sets up the story of Hezekiah's strong faith and how God interacted with him (2 Kings 18:19–19:19).

2 Kings 18:13

The records of King Sennacherib of Assyria tell about this invasion during his third military campaign. He quickly moved down the Mediterranean coast through the Phoenician cities into Philistine land, then headed inland.

2 Kings 18:14

- Lachish was southwest of Jerusalem, near the Philistine border.
- I have done wrong (literally I have sinned): Hezekiah's message to Sennacherib used careful diplomatic language.
- Sennacherib claimed he received eleven tons of silver, one ton of gold, many jewels, and rich treasures from Hezekiah. He also said he received Hezekiah's daughter, the women of his harem, and his male and female singers.

2 Kings 18:15–16

Hezekiah faced severe consequences for not paying tribute to the king of Assyria. To meet Sennacherib's demands, he took all the silver and gold from the temple and the palace treasury (see 2 Chronicles 16:1–9).

2 Kings 18:17

- sent ... a great army: Despite Hezekiah's large payment, Sennacherib still planned to invade Jerusalem.
- by the aqueduct: The two groups likely met at a spot on Jerusalem's northwestern wall. This location also served as the meeting place between Isaiah and Ahaz (Isaiah 7:3–16).

2 Kings 18:19–22

- In the past, people used the term great king for leaders of major military powers. It later became a common title for Assyrian kings.
- What is the basis of this confidence of yours?: The Assyrian officer claimed that Jerusalem's citizens would be unwise to trust Hezekiah's words, given Assyria's strong military. Seeking help from Egypt would also be unwise. The chief of staff argued that trusting in the Lord was also a mistake. The officer might have hoped to win over citizens who had worshiped at the shrines and altars Hezekiah had destroyed.

2 Kings 18:23–24

The officer then mocked Jerusalem, saying it did not have enough soldiers or strength to resist even the weakest group of Assyrian troops.

2 Kings 18:25

The chief of staff ended his argument by saying Jerusalem was doomed. He claimed the Assyrians were sent by God to destroy Judah. Opposing the great king meant opposing God!

2 Kings 18:26

Please speak to your servants in Aramaic: Hezekiah's officials asked the Assyrian delegation to speak in Aramaic, which was the language of diplomacy. They did not want the people listening to understand and become discouraged or afraid.

2 Kings 18:27

my master sent me to speak ... to the men sitting on the wall: The Assyrian officials spoke in the local language so everyone in the city could understand. This was a way to spread fear and weaken the people's resolve, a form of psychological warfare.

2 Kings 18:28–30

The chief of staff ignored Hezekiah's delegation's request and shouted in Hebrew, trying to scare the people of Jerusalem.

2 Kings 18:31–32

The Assyrian chief of staff explained the generous terms Sennacherib offered for their surrender. Why choose death? Choose life instead!

2 Kings 18:32–35

- The LORD will deliver us: The Assyrian chief of staff mocked Judah's trust in the Lord. He claimed that the Lord was no different from the gods of other nations and could not save them.
- Arpad was a city-state northwest of Aleppo. Like Hamath, it was a center of Aramean activity and is mentioned elsewhere in the Old Testament (see Isaiah 10:9; Jeremiah 49:23).

2 Kings 18:37

Tearing clothes was a traditional way to show deep sorrow. In this case, it may have shown grief over Jerusalem's trouble (see 2 Kings 6:30) and also over the insults spoken against God by the Assyrian official (see 2 Kings 19:4–6).

2 Kings 19:1

Hezekiah expressed his grief like his representatives did (see Joel 1:13). He wisely went to the temple, where he openly shared his feelings with God through sincere worship and prayer (see Psalms 5:7; 48:9–10; 63:1–3).

2 Kings 19:2–3

- Leaders often asked prophets like Isaiah for guidance during emergencies (2 Kings 3:11–12) or before battles (1 Kings 22:8–10). Isaiah was active during King Hezekiah's rule (2 Kings 20:1, 14).
- The phrase day of distress describes the deep distress the king felt due to the insults and disgrace against God and his people. Hezekiah understood that they were powerless without God's help.

2 Kings 19:4

Hezekiah was not denying his own relationship with the Lord by calling him your God; instead, he was recognizing God's special call on Isaiah.

2 Kings 19:8

Sennacherib sent his officers and troops to Jerusalem while he attacked Lachish (2 Kings 18:14, 17). He then moved eight miles northeast to Libnah.

2 Kings 19:9

King Tirhakah of Ethiopia later became the pharaoh of Egypt. At this time, he was a commander in his brother Shebitku's army.

2 Kings 19:10–13

Sennacherib's second message warned the people of Jerusalem about the Assyrians' brutal victories. Everyone knew the Assyrian kings had looted, tortured, and destroyed those who opposed them (see 2 Kings 19:28). No nation, king, or god had stopped them. Facing this threat, the people should use common sense and surrender instead of trusting Hezekiah and his misleading religious devotion.

2 Kings 19:14–19

Hezekiah got Sennacherib's disrespectful letter and took it straight to the temple of the Lord. He prayed to God with both praise (2 Kings 19:15) and requests (2 Kings 19:16–19).

2 Kings 19:16–19

Sennacherib's victories did not matter because, unlike the false gods of other nations, Yahweh was the true living God.

2 Kings 19:21–28

The phrase Virgin Daughter is often used to describe a city or nation (Isaiah 23:12; 37:22; 47:1; Jeremiah 18:13). Here, it means that just as a young woman is saved from danger, God will save Jerusalem. The Lord's response came as a "taunt song," a common ancient Near Eastern literary form that celebrated an enemy's defeat (see Isaiah 14:3–20).

2 Kings 19:23–24

the heights of the mountains ... of Lebanon: In his records, Sennacherib described climbing high mountain passes and cutting down Lebanon's great trees. Sennacherib felt unbeatable, but he was just a man, no match for the all-knowing Lord of the universe (1 Chronicles 28:9).

2 Kings 19:25–26

I have brought it to pass: God planned all of Sennacherib's great accomplishments.

2 Kings 19:27–28

- I know your sitting down: See Psalms 44:21; 94:11.
- My hook ... and My bit: The Assyrian records describe similar harsh treatment of prisoners. The Lord would treat Sennacherib as he and his ancestors treated those they conquered.

2 Kings 19:29–30

this will be a sign: The Lord's message of hope included a sign that Jerusalem would be saved from the siege. The sign was God providing food. Since the Assyrians had devastated the land, people would rely on random crop growth to survive. The food supply would still be limited the following year. But by the third year, regular planting and harvesting would resume.

2 Kings 19:31

The idea of a remnant (a small surviving group) appears often in the Old Testament. God often preserves his people, promising to care for them in the future (see Isaiah 4:2–6; 9:127; Zephaniah 3:8–20; compare Revelation 7:1–12). God's people can trust they will survive because the Lord is committed to making it happen.

2 Kings 19:32–34

- Sennacherib's armies did not enter Jerusalem and instead returned home. In his own account, Sennacherib described capturing and plundering forty-six cities in Judah. He did not mention capturing Jerusalem but noted that he trapped Hezekiah "in Jerusalem ... like a bird in a cage."
- For my own honor—considering Sennacherib's disrespect and arrogance toward God (see 2 Kings 18:25, 28–30; 19:10–13, 21, 27–28)—and for the sake of my servant David, to whom God had made a covenant promise (2 Samuel 7:8–16) and whose faith Hezekiah had followed (2 Kings 18:3), the Lord would protect this city (see 2 Kings 20:6). The Lord clearly showed that he alone is God and that he is loyal to his people who trust in him.

2 Kings 19:35

The angel of the Lord also helped rescue God's people from Egypt (Exodus 12:12–13, 23).

2 Kings 19:36

Sennacherib ... returned to Nineveh and stayed there: Although this Assyrian king led five more military campaigns, he did not attack Judah again.

2 Kings 19:37

- his sons ... put him to the sword: Although Sennacherib's assassination occurred twenty years later in 681 BC, the narrator mentions it here to finish discussing the Assyrian king and highlight the irony of his death. Sennacherib had bragged that no gods could save the people he attacked, yet his own

god could not protect him from assassins within his family.
- At Sennacherib's death, his son Esarhaddon took over and ruled until 669 BC.

2 Kings 20:1

- Isaiah was already active during Hezekiah's reign before Sennacherib tried to capture Jerusalem. He was available to the king during that crisis (2 Kings 19:2).
- Put your house in order: Hezekiah's illness was fatal.

2 Kings 20:1–19

In those days: This phrase gives a general time reference. It shows that the events are grouped by theme, not by strict order of time. The story about Merodach-baladan (2 Kings 20:12–19), who Sennacherib had expelled from Babylon before 701 BC, occurred before the events in chapters 18–19 but after Hezekiah's illness (2 Kings 20:12).

2 Kings 20:2–3

Ahab went to bed sulking (1 Kings 21:4). But Hezekiah turned his face to the wall and prayed.

2 Kings 20:5

Hezekiah's dedication to the Lord was similar to his ancestor David's (2 Kings 18:3). Just as God listened to David's prayers (Psalms 6:8–9; 28:6–7; 31:22; 40:1–2), he would also respond to Hezekiah's request.

2 Kings 20:6

- When God gave Hezekiah more years to live, he also promised to protect Jerusalem. When Hezekiah responded to Sennacherib's later invasion (2 Kings 19:14–19) by asking Isaiah for advice (2 Kings 19:2), he was following a well-known example.
- for My sake and for … David: God reminded Hezekiah of this promise during Sennacherib's invasion (2 Kings 19:34).

2 Kings 20:8

Hezekiah wanted a sign to prove his healing, which makes sense. He went from having a terminal illness to being promised fifteen more years of life. God sometimes gave signs as visible symbols of his plans (see also 2 Kings 19:29; Genesis 9:12–17; Exodus 4:1–9; 12:12–13; 31:12–13, 17; 1 Kings 13:1–3).

2 Kings 20:10

go back ten steps: The shadow's retreat was unnatural, and this miracle confirmed God's message to Hezekiah.

2 Kings 20:12–13

- Merodach-baladan ruled Babylon from 721 to 710 BC until Sargon of Assyria forced him to flee. He briefly ruled again in 703 BC. This visit likely happened during his exile; he probably sent envoys with good wishes and a gift because he needed an ally against Assyria.
- There was nothing … Hezekiah did not show them: Hezekiah showed the Babylonian envoys his vast treasuries, which had not yet been sent to Sennacherib (2 Kings 18:13–16). However, his attempt to impress them was unwise (2 Kings 20:16–18).

2 Kings 20:17

all … will be carried off to Babylon: The Lord's message through Isaiah predicted that the palace treasures in Jerusalem would be taken to Babylon, which happened between 597 and 586 BC (2 Kings 24:10–17; 25:1–21).

2 Kings 20:18

some of your descendants … will be taken away: Hezekiah's son Manasseh was captured and taken to Babylon (2 Chronicles 33:11–13). This prophecy was fully realized with Hezekiah's descendants during the Babylonian deportations in:

- 605 BC (see 2 Kings 24:1 and 2 Kings 24:1; Daniel 1:1–7),
- 597 BC (2 Kings 24:10–12; 2 Chronicles 36:10), and
- 586 BC (2 Kings 25:5–7; 2 Chronicles 36:20; Jeremiah 39:1–7; 52:4–15).

2 Kings 20:20

- For more about Hezekiah's power, see 2 Kings 18:7–8; 2 Chronicles 32:27–29.
- When Sennacherib threatened Jerusalem, Hezekiah built a 1,777-foot tunnel to bring water into the city (2 Chronicles 32:1–5, 30). The tunnel brough water into the Pool of Siloam. An inscription found in AD 1880 honors this engineering achievement.

2 Kings 21:1–2

- fifty-five years: Manasseh's long rule, from 697 to 642 BC was not due to his faithfulness to the Lord, but because the Lord honored his covenant promises (see also 2 Kings 8:19; 19:34; 20:6; 2 Samuel

7:11–16). External conditions were mostly stable. Although Assyrian kings Esarhaddon (680–669 BC) and Ashurbanipal (668–626 BC) led several military campaigns, they did not target Judah until later in Manasseh's reign, likely around 650 to 648 BC (see 2 Chronicles 33:10–13). Ashurbanipal focused on building projects, religious activities, and the arts, including creating a great library.
- he did evil: Manasseh was the most wicked king of Judah. Discussions about his reign highlight his evil religious practices.

2 Kings 21:3–5

Manasseh turned away from his faith by rebuilding local pagan shrines that his father had destroyed (2 Kings 18:3). He also encouraged evil religious practices linked to Baal worship and set up an Asherah pole (see 2 Kings 18:3; 1 Kings 16:32) and brought back the worship of stars. God had judged the northern kingdom for these sins (2 Kings 17:16).

2 Kings 21:6

- Manasseh's evil actions included taking part in the terrible Molech ceremonies and various forbidden cult and occult practices (2 Kings 16:3; see Leviticus 18:21).
- provoking Him to anger: God reacted to Manasseh's awful religious practices with fair judgment, just as he did with the northern kingdom (2 Kings 17:18–20).

2 Kings 21:11

- The Amorites lived in the land before the Israelites and were known for their wickedness.
- Manasseh followed the idolatrous practices of the Amorites, just as Ahab did (1 Kings 21:26).

2 Kings 21:12

Given what happened to the northern kingdom (2 Kings 17:7–23) and Ahab's family (2 Kings 9:24–26, 30–37; 10:1–8; 1 Kings 22:37–38), Manasseh should expect God to bring justice to him and the people of Judah.

2 Kings 21:14–15

the remnant: Those not killed in God's coming judgment would be at the mercy of their captors. This prophecy came true when thousands of Judeans were taken captive during the Babylonian invasion and the fall of Jerusalem in 586 BC (2 Kings 25:8–21; 2 Chronicles 36:20; Jeremiah 39:9; 52:15).

2 Kings 21:16

innocent blood: Besides his terrible spiritual sins, Manasseh committed murder. According to Jewish tradition, Manasseh killed many prophets, including Isaiah.

2 Kings 21:17

all his accomplishments: The writer of Chronicles notes that Manasseh was captured by an Assyrian king. This likely happened when King Ashurbanipal was in Babylon, around 650 to 648 BC. This event humbled Manasseh and led to his repentance. After his release, he tried to make spiritual changes, but it was too late in his reign for them to succeed (2 Chronicles 33:11–17).

2 Kings 21:18

The garden of Uzza is not mentioned elsewhere (but see also 2 Kings 21:26). Unlike his father Hezekiah, who was buried with honor, Manasseh was not buried in the royal tombs (2 Chronicles 32:33).

2 Kings 21:19–22

- Amon ruled briefly from 642 to 640 BC and continued his father's evil ways. Manasseh's repentance and reforms were too late to influence Amon or the people of Judah.
- He abandoned the LORD: Amon completely rejected his faith (see also 2 Chronicles 33:23).

2 Kings 21:26

Like his father Manasseh (2 Kings 21:17), Amon was not buried in the royal tombs. He was buried in the garden of Uzza instead.

2 Kings 22:1–2

- Josiah became the king of Judah in 640 BC. Like Joash (2 Kings 11:21), he was still a child when he became king. He was loyal to the Lord, much like David, Asa (1 Kings 15:11), and Hezekiah (2 Kings 18:3).
- did what was right: Josiah's actions followed the high standards of the law (Deuteronomy 17:11; 28:14).

2 Kings 22:3–4

- By the eighteenth year of his reign, which was in 621 BC, Josiah had followed the Lord for ten years (see 2 Chronicles 34:3–7).
- Hilkiah, the high priest, came from Zadok's family line (1 Chronicles 9:10–11). Some scholars think this Hilkiah was Jeremiah's father (Jeremiah 1:1).

- The money was collected in a large chest placed where people could easily access it as they entered the temple (compare 2 Kings 12:9).

2 Kings 22:5–7

Josiah gave Shaphan instructions similar to those Joash gave for repairing the temple during his rule (2 Kings 12:10–15).

2 Kings 22:8–10

The scroll called the Book of the Law might have included all or part of Deuteronomy or even the entire Pentateuch (compare Deuteronomy 31:26). We do not know how it was lost or where it was found in the temple. Shaphan quickly reported the important discovery and read it to the king.

2 Kings 22:11–13

- Like Hezekiah before him (2 Kings 19:1), Josiah tore his clothes in deep sorrow for his own spiritual state and that of the people of Judah.
- have not obeyed the words of this book: The part Shaphan read to Josiah reminded him of God's claim on his people, the need to stay faithful to the covenant, and the consequences for unfaithfulness (see Deuteronomy 28). Realizing that Judah had not followed the law, Josiah rightly feared the Lord's great anger.

2 Kings 22:14

Huldah the prophetess, the wife of Shallum: Some suggest Shallum was related to Jeremiah (see Jeremiah 32:7–12). Huldah's family ties might have let her serve as a court prophet (see also 2 Chronicles 34:22–28).

2 Kings 22:15–17

this is what the LORD says: Like Miriam (Exodus 15:20) and Deborah (Judges 4:4), Huldah had the honor of sharing God's message with the people. Huldah confirmed Josiah's fears that God would punish Jerusalem for the people's unfaithfulness and many sins.

2 Kings 22:18–20

God praised Josiah for his sorrow and humility after hearing God's word. Although God's judgment was sure, God would delay it until after Josiah's death.

2 Kings 23:1–2

Following the instructions in Deuteronomy (Deuteronomy 31:10–13) and the example of Joshua (Joshua 8:34–35), Josiah called all the people to listen to the reading of the entire Book of the Covenant.

2 Kings 23:3

the king ... made a covenant: The king ... renewed the covenant: God's people renewed their covenant (their promises with God) at several important times in history (see 2 Kings 11:12, 17; Joshua 24:1–27; 1 Kings 8:1–53).

2 Kings 23:4

- remove ... all the articles: Josiah removed detestable items related to pagan worship from the temple.
- the fields of Kidron: The fields of the Kidron Valley were close to the Valley of Ben-Hinnom. In that valley, people once carried out ceremonies for the god Molech. These ceremonies involved burning children as sacrifices. Later, the Kidron Valley became a place where ashes and dead bodies were taken (Jeremiah 26:23).
- Taking the ashes to Bethel, where Jeroboam set up one of his cult altars (1 Kings 12:28–29), would defile the site forever.

2 Kings 23:5–7

Josiah removed the priests who led idol worship. He also destroyed the living places of the cult prostitutes. These practices had been allowed by Manasseh and Amon. They continued the prostitution that came from Canaanite religion (see 1 Kings 14:24; 15:12; 22:46). Shockingly, this was practiced inside the temple itself.

2 Kings 23:8–9

The gate of Joshua is not mentioned elsewhere. It might have been used by the city governor. This title refers to a city official in Samaria (1 Kings 22:26; 2 Chronicles 18:25) and to Maaseiah in Jerusalem (2 Chronicles 34:8).

2 Kings 23:10

- Topheth was an area in the valley of Ben-Hinnom, southwest of the city of David, leading into the Kidron Valley. People once practiced child sacrifice there.
- Molech is linked to several gods (see 1 Kings 11:5, 7, 33) and is also associated with a sacrifice offered to Baal (Jeremiah 7:31–32; 19:5–6; 32:35).

2 Kings 23:11

- In the ancient Near East, people often used the horse in ceremonies that honored the sun. The Assyrian sun-god Shamash and other gods were

shown riding in horse-drawn chariots across the sky. Archaeological findings suggest that a solar cult (worship of the sun) existed in Israel as early as the 800s BC. This practice grew more popular during the reigns of Manasseh and Amon, when the royal court supported it (2 Kings 21:3–5, 21–22).

King Josiah tried to end these practices with his reforms. But after his death, the prophet Ezekiel condemned people again for sun worship. He described them as bowing down to the sun in the inner court of the temple (Ezekiel 8:16).

- an official: This word eunuch (translated official in the Berean Standard Bible) does not always mean a man who was physically made a eunuch. It can also mean a high-ranking court official who served the king.

2 Kings 23:12

the upper chamber of Ahaz: People used rooftop altars for star worship (Jeremiah 19:13; Zephaniah 1:5) and Baal rituals (Jeremiah 32:29).

2 Kings 23:13

Solomon built the pagan shrines because he had many foreign wives (1 Kings 11:5, 7, 33).

2 Kings 23:15–17

Jeroboam built the altar at Bethel to make it easier for Israelites to worship nearby instead of traveling to Jerusalem (1 Kings 12:26–31). Josiah's destruction of the site followed the law's requirements (Deuteronomy 7:5; 12:3) and fulfilled the earlier prophecy by the man of God who had condemned the altar (1 Kings 13:1–3).

2 Kings 23:19–20

Samaria ... high places: Josiah's religious reforms reached the former northern kingdom (see also 2 Chronicles 34:6–7). Josiah's ability to make these changes shows his power and Assyria's decline (see study note on 2 Kings 23:29).

2 Kings 23:21–23

- Hezekiah celebrated the Passover with some changes (2 Chronicles 30:1–4, 13, 23–27). Josiah's Passover followed the law's strict rules (2 Chronicles 35:1–19).
- The eighteenth year was when they found the Book of the Law (2 Kings 22:3, 8).

2 Kings 23:24–25

Josiah's dedication to the law led to changes in Jerusalem and Judah. He worked hard to remove all bad practices and strictly observed Passover. This made him the greatest king in following the laws of Moses.

2 Kings 23:26–27

I will remove Judah: Even though Josiah made strong reforms, Manasseh's wickedness was deeply rooted among the people. Josiah could not change their unfaithful hearts, so they would face the consequences for breaking God's covenant (Deuteronomy 28:15–68).

2 Kings 23:28–30

The end of Josiah's reign includes a historical note about his death by Pharaoh Neco (see also 2 Chronicles 35:20–25).

2 Kings 23:29

In 609 BC, Pharaoh Neco was heading to the Euphrates River to assist the Assyrian king against the Babylonians at Haran. Josiah confronted him at Megiddo.

After Assyrian king Ashurbanipal died in 626 BC, Assyrian cities began falling to Nabopolassar, the king of the growing Neo-Babylonian empire.

Nabopolassar captured Nineveh, Assyria's capital, in 612 BC. The Assyrian forces retreated to Haran, where the Babylonians defeated them in 609 BC.

Nebuchadnezzar II of Babylon later defeated the remaining Assyrians at Carchemish in 605 BC, the same year he first invaded Judah (see 2 Kings 24:1).

2 Kings 23:30

The writer of Chronicles tells how Josiah was greatly honored after his death (2 Chronicles 35:24–25).

2 Kings 23:31–34

- Jehoahaz was originally named Shallum at birth (see study note on 1 Chronicles 3:15). His throne name, Jehoahaz, has been found on seals from the 600s BC. He became king at twenty-three, while his brother Jehoiakim was twenty-five (2 Kings 23:36). There is no explanation for why the younger brother became king.
- Jehoahaz reigned for three months in 609 BC, possibly during the time when Pharaoh Neco was trying to help the Assyrians (2 Kings 23:29).

2 Kings 23:32

he did evil in the sight of the LORD: The deep-rooted evil and turning away from faith of the time appeared even in Josiah's sons (2 Kings 23:32, 37; 24:9, 19). The Lord planned to judge Judah (2 Kings 23:26–27), and this decision was justified and would soon happen.

2 Kings 23:33

Riblah was a strong administrative center in Aramean territory, located about sixty miles northeast of Damascus.

2 Kings 23:34

Eliakim ... Jehoiakim: Neco followed the Assyrian tradition of demanding a loyalty oath and giving a new name to the local leader.

2 Kings 23:36

Jehoiakim, Jehoahaz's older brother (see 2 Kings 23:31), ruled for eleven years from 609 to 598 BC.

2 Kings 23:37

did evil: The book of Jeremiah describes Jehoiakim as completely unfaithful (see Jeremiah 22:13–23; 25:1–14; 26:20–23; 36:1–32).

2 Kings 24:1

In 605 BC, Nebuchadnezzar led forces that defeated the last Assyrian army and an Egyptian group at Carchemish (see Jeremiah 46:2). While he was campaigning in the west, his father, Nabopolassar, died.

Nebuchadnezzar returned home to become king as Nebuchadnezzar II from 605 to 562 BC. When he rejoined his troops, they easily advanced down the Mediterranean coast. During this campaign, he invaded Judah, taking much treasure and many captives to Babylon, including Daniel and his three friends (Daniel 1:1–7). Jehoiakim became a vassal to Nebuchadnezzar and paid him tribute for three years.

When Pharaoh Neco defeated the Babylonians at the Egyptian border in 601 BC, Jehoiakim rebelled, hoping to gain independence.

2 Kings 24:1–25.21

Nebuchadnezzar II attacked Judah at least three times, in 605 BC, 597 BC, and 586 BC.

He took treasures from Jerusalem and captured people to bring to Babylon (see 2 Kings 24:1, 10–17; 25:1–21).

2 Kings 24:2

Nebuchadnezzar waited from 601 to 598 BC while strengthening his control over the west. He sent raiders to attack Judah.

2 Kings 24:3

at the LORD's command: Judah's main issue was its stubborn spiritual unfaithfulness. Even with Josiah's reforms, Manasseh's sins deeply affected Judah, making divine judgment unavoidable.

2 Kings 24:4

innocent blood: Tradition says that Manasseh killed the prophet Isaiah by cutting him in half (see Hebrews 11:37).

2 Kings 24:6

Jehoiakim died in 598 BC, likely during Nebuchadnezzar's second attack on Jerusalem. Josephus says Nebuchadnezzar executed Jehoiakim (see Josephus, Antiquities 10.6.3; compare Jeremiah 22:18–19; 36:30–31).

2 Kings 24:7

- The king of Egypt stayed in his country because Nebuchadnezzar was too powerful. Judah's hope for help from Egypt was useless (see Jeremiah 2:36; 46:2–12; Ezekiel 29:6, 16).
- The Brook of Egypt is thought to be either the Wadi el-Arish near the Nile delta or Nahal Besor, south of Gaza.

2 Kings 24:8

- Jehoiachin became king in 597 BC.
- He ruled in Jerusalem for three months (see Jeremiah 22:28–30).

2 Kings 24:10–12

- Jehoiachin gave up when Nebuchadnezzar's powerful army approached. See study note on 2 Chronicles 36:9–10.
- Nebuchadnezzar's eighth year as king was 597 BC.

2 Kings 24:13

- As the LORD had declared: See 2 Chronicles 20:16–17. A greater divine judgment was still to come (2 Kings 21:12–15; 22:15–20; 23:26–27).
- all the treasures: During his earlier attack on Jerusalem in 605 BC, Nebuchadnezzar took some of the temple treasures as loot (2 Chronicles 36:7; Daniel 1:2). He now took all the treasures. Anything

left behind was taken during his final attack on Jerusalem in 586 BC (2 Kings 25:15).

2 Kings 24:14–16

- Along with Jehoiachin, the prophet Ezekiel was also taken into captivity (Ezekiel 1:1). The book of Ezekiel dates events in his life based on the years since Jehoiachin's capture.
- The 10,000 people taken captive by Nebuchadnezzar likely included:
- 7,000 troops,
- 1,000 craftsmen and artisans, and
- several administrative officials and leading citizens of Jerusalem.

The number 10,000 is probably an estimate (see also Jeremiah 52:28).

2 Kings 24:17

- Like the three kings before him, Mattaniah was given a throne name. His throne name was Zedekiah.
- Jehoiachin's uncle: See 1 Chronicles 3:15–16.

2 Kings 24:18–20

- Zedekiah ruled Jerusalem for eleven years, from 597 to 586 BC, and was as evil as Jehoiakim (2 Kings 23:36–37). The Lord was punishing Jerusalem and Judah for their sins (see 2 Kings 17:19; 20:16–17; 21:12–15; 22:15–20; 23:26–27).
- Zedekiah also rebelled: His rebellion might have been part of an anti-Babylonian alliance led by Pharaoh Apries of Egypt. When Apries became king around 589 BC, he wanted to restore Egypt's former glory. Zedekiah seemed to trust him (compare Ezekiel 17:15–18). However, like earlier kings (2 Kings 17:4; 24:1–3), Zedekiah found that Egypt offered little help (compare 2 Kings 18:20–21; Jeremiah 37:3–10; Ezekiel 29:6–7).

2 Kings 25:1

Siege ramps were common in ancient Near Eastern warfare. Attackers built a siege wall (tall dirt ramps and towers) to gain a better position (see Jeremiah 52:14; Ezekiel 21:22).

2 Kings 25:4

The Babylonians used battering rams (Ezekiel 4:2) to break a part of Jerusalem's wall and enter the city. At nightfall, King Zedekiah and the remaining troops escaped through the gate at the southeastern corner of the city into the Kidron Valley, trying to reach the Jordan Valley.

2 Kings 25:6

Riblah, once an Assyrian administrative center, was Nebuchadnezzar's battle headquarters. It also served the Egyptians (2 Kings 23:33).

2 Kings 25:7

- they put out his eyes: In the ancient Near East, rebellious leaders were often blinded. Zedekiah's blinding was especially cruel because his last sight was his sons being killed.
- True to the prophecy, Zedekiah was captured and died in captivity (Jeremiah 32:4–5; 34:3; 52:11; Ezekiel 12:11–14).

2 Kings 25:8

Nebuzaradan is known from one of Nebuchadnezzar's writings as a high-ranking official.

2 Kings 25:9–10

every significant building: The Babylonians destroyed important religious and government buildings to prevent further rebellion. They also tore down the city's walls, leaving Jerusalem defenseless.

2 Kings 25:11–12

- The Babylonians exiled most of the population, including some who willingly joined them (Jeremiah 39:9; 52:15).
- They left the poorest people behind because they were unlikely to cause trouble and could work the vineyards and fields.

2 Kings 25:13–16

The Babylonians dismantled the temple furnishings made by Huram of Tyre and other bronze items (see 1 Kings 7:13–50) for their own use. Transporting these valuable items to Babylon was a major task. They took everything valuable (see also Jeremiah 52:17–23).

2 Kings 25:17

The bronze capital (the decorated top part of the pillar) was 3 cubits high (about 1.4 meters or 4.5 feet). Some ancient copies read 5 cubits (about 2.3 meters or 7.5 feet). This larger number may describe the entire capital, while the Hebrew text may describe only the decorative network of bronze pomegranates (compare 1 Kings 7:17–18).

2 Kings 25:18–20

- Instead of deporting important citizens and officials like during the Babylonian invasion of 597 BC (2

Kings 24:14), Nebuchadnezzar executed these leaders. He even had religious leaders killed.
- Seraiah, the high priest, was killed. But his son Jehozadak was exiled (1 Chronicles 6:15). This allowed the priestly line to continue in captivity and later return to Jerusalem, starting in 538 BC (Ezra 1:1–2:20).

2 Kings 25:21

The people of Judah were exiled from their land. Like the northern kingdom before them, Judah was exiled as punishment for breaking their covenant. A small group later returned to the promised land in 538 BC (2 Chronicles 36:22–23; Ezra 1:1–2:20; see also 2 Chronicles 36:15–21; Jeremiah 25:11; 29:10; Daniel 9:2).

2 Kings 25:22

Gedaliah's father, Ahikam, and grandfather, Shaphan, were trusted officials when Josiah was king (2 Kings 22:3, 12). Ahikam supported Jeremiah during Jehoiakim's reign (Jeremiah 26:24).

2 Kings 25:22–30

Two short sections describe what happened next. The first explains how the land was reorganized (2 Kings 25:22–26). The second tells how King Jehoiachin was later treated kindly (2 Kings 25:27–30).

2 Kings 25:23–24

- Gedaliah's family had experience in civic matters, so people initially accepted his role as governor (see also Jeremiah 40:1–12). A seal impression found at Lachish shows Gedaliah's importance as the officer "over the house" (see study note on 1 Kings 4:6).
- The prophet Jeremiah, along with army commanders, went to Mizpah to support Gedaliah (Jeremiah 40:6). This Mizpah was a border town in Benjamin and was known in Israelite history as a place for religious gatherings (1 Samuel 7:5–6).
- The men mentioned here held significant positions. Ishmael came from a royal family (2 Kings 25:25; Jeremiah 36:12). Johanan was a loyal supporter of Gedaliah (Jeremiah 40:13–16). The name Jezaniah appears on items found during excavations at Tell-en-Nasbeh.

2 Kings 25:25

Gedaliah was warned that Ishmael planned to kill him, but he did not believe it (Jeremiah 40:13–16). His trust led to his death. Ishmael also killed many Judeans and Babylonians, took many captives, and escaped to Ammon (Jeremiah 41:4–15).

2 Kings 25:26

All the people of Judah, led by Johanan, fled in fear to Egypt. They did this even though the prophet Jeremiah had warned them not to go (see Jeremiah 42:1–43:7).

2 Kings 25:27–30

- Evil-merodach (Babylonian, Amel-marduk, meaning "man of Marduk") took over after Nebuchadnezzar II died and ruled briefly from 561 to 560 BC.
- he spoke kindly to Jehoiachin: Babylonian records detail the food Jehoiachin received in prison. The mention of Jehoiachin living comfortably might suggest hope that God would protect and bring back a repentant people to their land (see 1 Kings 8:46–53; Isaiah 35:8–10; 51:11; Jeremiah 29:10–14; Zephaniah 3:20).